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M3. Ethics of Education Agents

International students and French institutions alike must be able to trust the education agents they work with. Students may never have travelled overseas before, let alone to France, and will be relying on the agent to provide them with accurate information on which they can justify a substantial financial investment in their education. French institutions must have faith in agents to represent them accurately to international students so students know exactly what to expect from the experience should they decide to enroll.

Without this trust the role of the agent breaks down and both students and institutions may come to the decision that they are better off without agents' involvement. This outcome is highly undesirable as agents can serve such an important function in making international student recruitment and mobility more efficient and successful. Therefore, trustworthiness is a key quality for agents to possess when performing their roles.

Trustworthiness is the outcome of routinely practicing certain honest and professional behaviours and standards of conduct. Education agents who are trustworthy:

- Are absolutely clear on what an international student wants to achieve through studying in France;
- Know how to match students' goals to available schools, programmes, and courses;
- Provide complete advice to students—not just idealised information they want to hear but accurate advice that includes not just the benefits of a study plan but also potential drawbacks;
- Commit to the profession with long-term goals in mind, such as a reputation for integrity and excellent referrals and thus the steady

growth of business.

ICEF, the international organisation that connects international students, agents and education institutions across the globe, sums up education agents' ethical responsibilities in its IATC (International Agents Training Course) like this:*

When dealing with students, the education agent should:

- Provide sufficient and accurate information;
- Keep adequate records;
- Maintain contact after a course has begun;
- Have clear cost structures;
- Respond to questions in a timely manner.

When dealing with education institutions, the education agent should:

- Submit applications to institutions only from students who have a genuine interest;
- Communicate appropriately with organisations;
- Represent the institution and its courses accurately;
- Advertise with approval.

The following is a list of DOs and DON'Ts for education agents representing French institutions:

Do

- Check that institutions have supplied accurate and up-to-date information;
- Check that information is in language students can understand;
- Ensure students really understand the benefits/drawbacks of a particular study choice so they can make an informed decision;
- Treat students' information confidentially and carefully;
- Keep students' money in secure accounts until due for payment, then pay it promptly into the proper accounts;
- Meet all contractual obligations with education institutions, particularly in relation to marketing, recruitment, and information given to students;
- Keep up to date on entry and border requirements for France, and ensure all students are aware of any changes which may affect them;

- Consider ways to add value to the service you provide to prospective students (e.g., translating enrolment and visa applications for students who would otherwise struggle to understand them);
- Visit France and the education institution partners.

Don't

- Provide information that results in misleading or unfair comparisons between institutions;
- Provide false or overly idealised information about likely employment post-study or an institution's facilities;
- Persuade students to go to a school or programme if it is not well aligned with their educational interests;
- Pass students' information on to other businesses or people without the permission of the student;
- Charge students fees for services progressively without informing students from the beginning;
- Persuade students to enroll in a course or programme for which they are inadequately prepared (e.g., language proficiency too low, or academic qualifications not yet sufficient);
- Provide paid immigration advice to students unless they are an authorised immigration representative.

We recommend that agents representing French education institutions register for ICEF's **IATC course** or a similar professional development programme offered by a reputable organisation.

**Based on Section C of the IATC (ICEF's training course for education agents).*

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